EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

What Will Messianic Times Be Like?

Given Monday 14 July 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 8:6-7

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 8 (The Final Redemption), the second half of Chapter 6 and Chapter 7

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 14 July 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Story So Far

"We're coming towards the end of Saadia's essay on Mashiach," perhaps the penultimate shiur on it.

- **Chapters 1 and 2:** the purpose of the redemption is to gather us in the land and make us God's chosen people there, with hope and encouragement that it will come.
- **Chapters 3 and 4:** following the Gemara, the redemption comes either at the fixed time, the **קץ**, or earlier through **teshuvah**. Saadia calculated what he believed was the *ketz*, and the class discussed the whole idea of calculating the end.
- **Chapter 5 and half of Chapter 6:** the word Mashiach finally appears. If we do teshuvah, the process is less painful and there is one Mashiach, **Mashiach ben David**. If we wait for the *ketz* without deserving it, we will be almost compelled to do teshuvah by our circumstances, through the process of **Mashiach ben Yosef**, who gathers followers and is killed by a Christian emperor. The Gemara already speaks of Mashiach ben Yosef and of his death; Saadia filled in the description from the verses.
- Either way, **Mashiach ben David** comes. The nations become subservient and carry the Jews home by every means of transport. There is a war with **Gog uMagog**, and we are victorious.

The main point last week: **it is a process**, perhaps months, perhaps years. At its end, everyone comes back to Eretz Yisrael from the four corners of the globe.

"This is very apt for the Three Weeks. It's a beautiful time to be studying this, as we prepare for Tishah b'Av and for what we're missing out on."

Chapter 6 (continued): Five Stages After the Ingathering

1. The ingathering of the believers

וכאשר יתקבצו החיים מישראל המאמינים כאשר זכרתים...

The Rabbi pointed out a striking word: **the believers**. "There seems to be still, even at this point, a choice to make." A Jew living somewhere in the world who sees what is happening and decides,

"I'm not up for this," will not go. "You can't just sit back and say, I'll wait for Mashiach to take me on eagle's wings and end up in Israel. We need to make a choice that this is the time now to go to Israel." Saadia says it will be the vast majority.

2. The resurrection

תהיה אז תחיית המתים, כאשר בארתי במאמר הקודם לזה

Once the process is nearly complete and most of Am Yisrael is in Israel, the resurrection happens, as explained in Essay 7. **Mashiach ben Yosef will be at their head**, among the very first to rise, "for he is a righteous man and a ruler," and the Creator will reward him with good. We who are alive will be reunited with the relatives who died before us.

3. The Beit HaMikdash

אז יחדש הבורא בנין מקדשו, כמו שנאמר כי בנה ה׳ ציון נראה בכבודו

"We say this verse many times on Tishah b'Av." It will be built with all the measurements and chambers described by **Yechezkel**, in the prophecy that begins **בעשרים וחמש שנה לגלותנו**.

Will it be built by God or by man? There is a dispute among the Rishonim. **Rashi** holds it will be entirely God-built; other Rishonim say it will be built by people. Saadia does not express a view. "You could say maybe it implies more that it's going to be Hashem, but I don't think there's a proof either way."

It will be made of precious stones:

ושמתי כדכד שמשתיך, ושעריך לאבני אקדח (Yeshayahu 54:12)

And the whole land will be settled, with no ruined place left:

והיה השרב לאגם, וצמאון למבועי מים (Yeshayahu 35:7)

People ask how the whole Jewish people will fit. Israel holds about ten million people in total today; worldwide there are perhaps another six million Jews. "It's not difficult if you think about the south, how much space there is." It is empty now because it is desert and hard to live in. "When we all gather there and we need the space," it will be irrigated and there will be room for everyone.

4. The light of the Shechinah

אז יאיר אור השכינה וזורח בבית המקדש, עד שיהיו המאורות נגדו כהים

The Shechinah will shine in the Mikdash so brightly that all other lights are dim beside it. As Saadia explained in Essay 2, that created light is brighter than any other. **קומי אורי כי בא אורך** (Yeshayahu 60:1). It will be so palpable that someone who does not know the way to the Mikdash will simply follow the light, "because it stretches from heaven to earth." "You won't need signposts telling you this is the way to the Kotel." The verse is **והלכו גוים לאורך** (Yeshayahu 60:3): the nations will walk by your light. "I don't know if he means it literally."

The Rabbi noted that the printed text has a whole paragraph missing at this point, with the verse for the next stage displaced into it.

5. Prophecy

In the missing paragraph, Saadia says **prophecy will rest on the people**, even the young. It will be so widespread that the nations will ask an ordinary Jew what happened yesterday and what

will happen tomorrow, and if he can answer, they will know he is from Israel:

ונודע בגוים זרעם, וצאצאיהם בתוך העמים (Yeshayahu 61:9)

Saadia and the Rambam on prophecy

The Rabbi recalled the debate from the essay on prophecy, studied over a year earlier:

	Saadia	The Rambam
What is prophecy?	**A gift from God**, granted to one who is fitting for it	**A human achievement**: refine your intellect and character "until you've tuned into the radio signal"
Why in the days of Mashiach?	People will simply be gifted with it	Seeing the Shechinah and all that is happening will drive people to work on themselves until they reach it

Everyone agrees that prophecy fluctuates: "You may tune in one day, you may tune out the next." And everyone agrees that **a portion of Am Yisrael will have prophecy**. "There's no distinction made between men and women." There were women prophets, and if a person refines himself, man or woman alike will receive it.

What the Rambam would say

On all these details, the Rambam would say: leave the exact chronology and mechanics until it happens. "Let it work out by itself." But **in general he agrees** with the ideas: there will be a Beit HaMikdash, there will be Eliyahu HaNavi, there will be a Mashiach, there will be a resurrection.

Has the Process Begun?

"Arguably, I think many would argue nowadays this process has begun in some sort or fashion." It may take another year, or fifty, or a hundred. But "the fact that we now have some state of sovereignty over the land of Israel is a clear sign that the messianic process has begun in some shape or manner." Are we fit for Mashiach ben David now? "Nobody can answer that." Yet some prophecies are already being fulfilled: "Israel's leading the way in being able to bring out water from the most desolate and dry places." "And *be'ezrat Hashem*, maybe speedily in our days, in the next few weeks, and then we can cancel Tishah b'Av."

Shabbetai Tzvi and the two Mashiachs

The Rabbi gave a historical example of the two-Mashiach idea "playing out in actual life." In the 1660s, the vast majority of Jews believed **Shabbetai Tzvi** was Mashiach. It is documented that many in Europe sold their houses and set off for Israel. The Sultan summoned him and offered him death or conversion, and in 1666 he converted to Islam. Some of his defenders then argued that this was **the death of Mashiach ben Yosef**: "killing" did not mean literal death but a spiritual death, conversion, and Mashiach ben David would follow in a few years. "Clearly that didn't happen. Retrospectively, we know for a fact he was a false Mashiach." But it shows people reinterpreting events to fit the two-Mashiach scheme.

It Will Last Until the End of the World

ויעמדו על הענין הזה כל ימי העולם, לא ישתנה ענינם

Once all five stages have happened, this state will continue for the rest of the world's existence:

ישראל נושע בה׳ תשועת עולמים (Yeshayahu 45:17)

But Saadia is troubled by the word "everlasting." As many Rishonim held, he believes **this world ends at 6,000 years**, and then comes **Olam HaBa, a newly created world** (the subject of Essay 9, after the summer). So why "everlasting salvation"? Saadia explains that the verse means it will have **no break**: no further war, no further exile, for as long as this world lasts. "Which for us now, according to Saadia, is about 214 years."

For the **Rambam**, by contrast, everything Saadia said is true, but the world does not end. We die and go to Olam HaBa, which is spiritual and exists now. No new world is created.

Choosing Good in the Days of Mashiach

העם יבחרו בעבודה ולא ימרו

In that period the people will choose to serve and not rebel:

ומל ה׳ אלהיך את לבבך," (Devarim 30:6), Hashem will circumcise your heart" to love and fear Him
"one of the most beautiful verses in the Torah."
ונתתי לכם לב חדש (Yechezkel 36:26), the famous verse which the Christians distorted": a new" heart, meaning the will to do what is right.

Why will they choose good? Because:

- they see **the light of the Shechinah** and have prophecy;
- they are **well provided for**;
- **no one oppresses them**;
- they **lack nothing** and succeed in all they do;
- there will be **no plague, no affliction, no illness**, and all mourning and sorrow will be gone.

It will be a world of joy and gladness, as if the heavens and the land were renewed:

כי הנני בורא שמים חדשים וארץ חדשה... כי הנני בורא את ירושלם גילה ועמה משוש (Yeshayahu 65:17-18)

"A new world in a metaphoric sense." How glorious, says Saadia, a world that is all joy, all service of God, all reward. And Tehillim:

אשר בנינו כנטעים... מזוינו מלאים... אלופינו מסבלים, אין פרץ ואין יוצאת (Tehillim 144:12-14)

"No breaching, no more war." That is the end of Chapter 6.

But where is free will?

The Rabbi noted that **Rav Crescas** famously raised the problem. Saadia himself said in Essay 7 that there will still be **free will and reward** in the days of resurrection and redemption. But if everyone will be inclined to choose good, where is the free will, and how can there be reward for something you were inclined to do?

The answer: there will still be free will, since reward requires it. But **the choice will not be between good and bad**, since no one will want to do bad. **It will be between good and better.** "We all want to do good. But how much are we going to push ourselves?" How motivated will I be to become even better than I already am? "That's still up for grabs." And on that basis there will still be reward in the next world, whether it is Saadia's new world or the Rambam's spiritual one.

"This is why we talk all the time about *Mashiach bimheirah beyamenu*. We want it now more than ever. We want to see an end to the suffering in the world, an end to the illnesses, an end to the sadness, an end to wars." It may take time, but everyone, including the Rambam, agrees we will enjoy it until the end of 6,000. "What will happen after 6,000? Wait and see. We'll see if the Rambam's right or Saadia was right."

Questions

The seventh millennium

A participant asked about the seventh millennium. In short (fuller treatment in Essay 9): for the **Rambam**, the 6,000/7,000 scheme is one Midrashic opinion, not to be followed. For **Saadia, the Ramban and many others**, the world ends at 6,000 and the next world is physical, body and soul. The Gemara speaks of a thousand years in which the world lies desolate. The Rabbi suggested that is not literal, but describes **a period in which souls grow used to being out of their physical bodies and ready for the new body** they will receive in the new world. "We don't go straight from the end of 6,000 into the new world."

Who is "ben David"?

"We've got no idea." *Ben David* means a descendant of David. How will we know? Interestingly, **Saadia never gives criteria** for identifying Mashiach anywhere in this essay. **The Rambam does**, in Hilchot Melachim Chapter 11, and this is where he spends most of his detail:

If a king arises from the House of David who studies Torah and keeps the mitzvot, compels all Israel to walk in the way of the Torah and repair its breaches, and fights the wars of Hashem, he is **presumed** to be Mashiach. If he succeeds, **builds the Mikdash in its place and gathers the dispersed of Israel**, he is **certainly** Mashiach. (Hilchot Melachim 11:4)

The Rambam also says one should not assume Mashiach must perform miracles and wonders. "According to the Rambam, Mashiach is a much more proactive thing": leading the wars, bringing people to Torah. "We'll see when that happens. We'll see who it is."

"There Is No Mashiach for Israel"

Before moving on, the Rabbi brought a famous statement in the Gemara (Sanhedrin), by **Rav Hillel** ("not Beit Hillel, a different Hillel"): **אין משיח לישראל**, "there is no Mashiach for Israel."

- **Rav Yosef Albo** (Sefer HaIkkarim 4:42, 1400s) understood that this sage held all the messianic prophecies were **already fulfilled** in the days of Chizkiyahu. Other Rabbis contradicted him. Some commentators say the prophecies were fulfilled at the start of the Second Temple, when Koresh ordered it built. Albo therefore concludes that, **unlike the Rambam**, he does not count belief in Mashiach as a principle of faith. "It's a true belief, which we have to believe." But one who denies it is not a heretic.
- **Rashi** explains that Hillel meant there would be **no specific person**: a redemption, but without an individual anointed one. "Remember, we've been learning at the beginning of Saadia the idea of there being a redemption." Either way, this opinion is rejected.

Chapter 7: Is the Redemption Conditional?

The last three chapters of the essay are polemical:

- **Chapters 7 and 8:** against **Jews**, the Karaites, "who believe Mashiach had already come," so that none of this will happen.
- **Chapter 9:** against the Christian belief that Mashiach has come in Jesus.

כי יש אנשים שנקראים יהודים, חושבים כי אלה הייעודים כולם ואלה הנחמות היו כולם בבית שני, ועברו ולא נשאר להם דבר

There are people "who call themselves Jews" who make two arguments:

1. **All the promises were fulfilled in the Second Temple period.** That is Chapter 8.
2. **The promises were conditional.** Verses such as **לא יבוא עוד שמשך וירחך לא יאסף**, "your sun will no longer set," were promised on condition that we not worship idols. It is like Moshe's **למען ירבו ימיכם וימי בניכם על האדמה**, which depends on **והיה אם שמע תשמעו**. Because we sinned, we lost our sovereignty, some promises were fulfilled in the Second Temple and the rest never will be. "Mashiach's not going to come."

Saadia examined the claim of a condition carefully and found it **false for five reasons**:

1. The Torah states its conditions; the consolations have none

Moshe's promises are explicitly conditional:

כי אם שמר תשמרון את כל המצוה הזאת... והוריש ה׳ את כל הגוים האלה (Devarim 11:22-23)

כי אם שמע תשמע בקלו... ואיבתי את איביך (Shemot 23:22)

והיה עקב תשמעון (Devarim 7:12)

"Throughout the Torah we always see: when you do this, this will happen." But the messianic consolations studied in the previous chapters contain **no condition**. They are "straightforward and outright promises."

2. The Torah also states the reverse

Moshe did not only say "if you listen, you will receive." He also gave the opposite: **והיה אם שכח תשכח את ה׳ אלהיך** (Devarim 8:19), and in the Torah reading of Tishah b'Av, **כי תוליד בנים... העידתי בכם היום** (Devarim 4:25-26), that we would be scattered. This is a **תנאי כפול**, a double condition. The consolations have no condition, let alone its reverse.

3. The promise is sworn like the covenant with Noach

כי מי נח זאת לי, אשר נשבעתי מעבר מי נח עוד על הארץ, כן נשבעתי מקצף עליך (Yeshayahu 54:9)

After the Flood, people still sinned, but Hashem had sworn never to bring another flood; He punishes them in other ways. So too our redemption is sworn like the waters of Noach. "True, we sinned. Hashem will punish us with other things, but He's not going to punish us by taking away the messianic redemption."

4. The promise includes that we will not sin

As Chapter 6 showed, part of the prophecy is that **the people will hold fast to service and not rebel**, and God knows all that will be. So even if there were a condition, it would do no harm, since in those days we will not sin, "all the more so when there is no condition."

5. The Torah itself swears to it

Some of these promises are sworn in the Torah itself, in Ha'azinu:

כי אשא אל שמים ידי, ואמרתי חי אנכי לעלם... אשכיר חצי מדם (Devarim 32:40-42)

"I'm promising it's going to happen." All these points refute the claim of a condition.

Summary

1. **After the ingathering of the believers** (going is still a choice), there will be **resurrection** (Mashiach ben Yosef first), the **Beit HaMikdash** of precious stones, a fully settled and irrigated land, the **light of the Shechinah** guiding the way, and **prophecy** throughout the people.
2. **Saadia vs the Rambam on prophecy:** a gift from God, or a human achievement. Both agree it will return, for men and women alike.
3. **Shabbetai Tzvi's followers** reinterpreted his conversion as the "death" of Mashiach ben Yosef.
4. **"Everlasting salvation"** means no break until this world ends at 6,000 years, for Saadia; the Rambam holds the world does not end.
5. **Choosing good:** with the Shechinah, prosperity, peace and no illness, people will choose to serve. The free choice that remains is **between good and better**, so reward remains (Rav Crescas).
6. **The Rambam's criteria** for Mashiach (Hilchot Melachim 11:4): presumed if he leads in Torah and fights Hashem's wars; certain if he builds the Mikdash and gathers the exiles.

   Albo, the prophecies were fulfilled in Chizkiyahu's day, so belief in Mashiach **"אין משיח לישראל":** is not a principle; Rashi, a redemption without a specific person. The opinion is rejected.
8. **Chapter 7:** the redemption is **not conditional**: no condition is stated, no reverse is stated, it is sworn like Noach's covenant, it includes our not sinning, and the Torah swears to it.

Coming Up

Next week, the last Monday shiur before the break: **Chapter 8**, Saadia's fifteen proofs that the prophecies were **not** fulfilled in the Second Temple period, "some beautiful prophecies," and **Chapter 9**, against the Christian claim. Then a break until around Rosh Chodesh Elul, at the end of August, to begin **Essay 9 on Olam HaBa**, followed by Essay 10 on behaviour and conduct.

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